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About

Writing/Opinion Index

Independent Research Index

Informal Research List

recent posts

[Node Conflation and Referential Collapse](#)

[AAAI 2026: Dual Encoding Spaces in LLMs for improved Mechanistic Interpretability](#)

[\[Archived\] Modelling Human Cognition with Five Attributes](#)

[Deception as Information Appreciation and Focus: why society, organizations, and our minds \(and human-made intelligence agents\) suffer from self-deception](#)

[AI Hype post: how LLM chatbots helped me get a research paper accepted at a very competitive conference over a couple weekends](#)

about



Pink noise in natural systems

February 4, 2026

Two first-principle theories on what produces pink noise

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What is Pink Noise

My interest in pink noise (described as $1/f$) comes from a background in cognitive neuroscience. Pink noise shows up in electroencephalography (EEG), magnetoencephalography (MEG), and apparently, even in channel noise at the

neuron cellular level. I haven't dealt with this area in years, but its considered largely unresolved:

Layman summary:

- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Pink_noise — sounds like a waterfall, used for tuning of professional audio systems, one of the most commonly observed signals in biology.

And for comprehensiveness, summaries on these:

- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/White_noise — sounds like static; in music or acoustics associated with hissing or used as input in combination with filters
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Brownian_noise — sounds like waterfall, heavy rainfall

More technical explanation of what it is:

- Great summary: http://www.scholarpedia.org/article/1/f_noise

Basically,

- **white** noise (constant power spectra, 'static', uncorrelated to time) differs from
- **pink** noise ($1/f$ power spectra, 'natural systems' like brains, heartbeats, vacuum tubs, etc, and in between white and brown) differs from
- **brown** noise ($1/f^2$, "Brownian motion" like integrated motion over time like)
- where all three can be described as $1/f^n$ (where $n = 0, 1, 2$, for white, pink, and brown).

Where does Pink Noise come from

The article referenced above says:

The widespread occurrence of signals exhibiting such behavior suggests that a generic mathematical explanation might exist.

And adds that:

no generally recognized physical explanation of $1/f$ noise has been proposed. Consequently, the ubiquity of $1/f$ noise is one of the oldest puzzles of contemporary physics and science in general.

This struck me as bizarre that a more satisfying explanation doesn't yet exist. All current explanations (the list can be found in the article or by other means) are disappointing for various reasons:

- Some are simply *descriptive* ('criticality' which basically defines ' $1/f$ ' as a reference point, and then describes systems distance from that...).
- Others are *circular* (McWhorter (1957): derives $1/f$ noise by starting with a $1/\tau$ distribution; Eliazar-Klafter model (2009 PNAS): derives $1/f$ noise by starting with $1/\omega$ distribution).
- And some others are *complex model-fitting* (ARIMA, etc).

Kaulakys 2005 (and the other two I mentioned above by name) are more interesting because they link concepts across different spaces: spacing between stochastic pulses is equivalent to spectra patterns (the first two, albeit by importing $1/f$ somewhere else, and using decaying pulses in parallel, but lets not get lost in the details), but are still unsatisfying because it requires multiple complex terms and essentially shifts the $1/f$ mystery into the new space.

The article above stresses the weakness of existing theories from a scientific point of view (e.g. none of these models can be distinguished from each other and therefore tested) which is legitimate criticism. However, that criteria is overly ambitious for me, and I'd be happy with *any* mathematical explanation that has *very simple starting assumptions* that can generate pink noise spectra, *without* complex terms, or circular importation of $1/x$ in the starting assumptions, and from a fundamental first principle.

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My thoughts on where Pink Noise comes from

I haven't shared these theories before but these both occurred to me many years ago when I first heard about pink noise (and, having skipped nearly all the coursework for engineering and signals, I just assumed these were known and probably taught already).

Theory #1: Pink noise is generated from oscillators packed a Random Recursive Tree

Lets start with a set of apparent observations that haven't been formally linked (anywhere I can find):

1. Integrating $1/f$ gives $\ln(f)$
 - In other words, the area under the curve of the power spectra of a pink noise system, is $\ln(f_2) - \ln(f_1)$
2. Euler's number, natural log (which is just log base e), have a well known ubiquitousness in nature, mathematics, statistics, probability, etc because it reflects
 - Secretary problem: essentially, stop observing and start evaluating candidates after N/e candidates
 - Multiplication/string problem: bend your string into N/e lengths to achieve maximum area/volume/etc
 - Entropy/probability: you can turn a multiplicative problem (joint probability) into an additive problem by using entropy ($\log[e]$ of the information/uncertainty, etc)
 - In all these cases, e represents an optimal point for that physical system between *multiplicative processes and additive processes*
3. Binary trees have a height of $\log[2](N)$, trinary trees $\log[3](N)$ (for balanced)
 - *Random recursive trees* (which have a really simple rule — node gets added randomly to any previous node) interestingly have a $\log[e](N)$ height of the tree.
 - Tons of other interesting relationships here including being able to add RRT to another RRT at a random node and, etc
4. Finally, if we consider other noise types and the simplest known tree structures who's derivative of mean depth matches the PSD, we get a nice looking pattern:
 - Pink ($1/f$): RRT structure, depth = $\ln(f) \rightarrow d/df = 1/f$
 - White (constant): Linked-list structure, depth = $f \rightarrow d/df = 1$
 - Brown ($1/f^2$): Flat-tree structure, depth = $(f-1)/f \rightarrow d/df = 1/f^2$

First, this implies that a natural packing (fully random) of oscillators resulting in an

RRT-like structure, results in the power spectra describing the distance (between nodes, or 'depth' in the tree) between two aggregate frequency bins (likely aggregate across the entire system, and only instantaneous to that moment measured).

- This is interesting because a random structure doesn't require any 'global coordination', and 'naturally' achieves (potentially) optimal packing of depth to branching of nodes.
- Nor does it 'privilege' any frequency bands ahead of time — although this RRT structure/metaphor currently assumes some kind of ordering as you pack.
- Implies deviations from $1/f$ might indicate interesting signal/organization against this state (probably as selective activations/deactivations, etc).

Second, this also implies that high-frequency oscillators contribute shorter paths (which sorta fits with short-distance intracortical communication being facilitated by gamma, longer range facilitated by alpha). And that they tend to be 'closer' in the connectivity structure (nodally).

- To not lose track of this mathematical structure's significance beyond a distant metaphor, think of the binary tree's depth equation ($\log_2(N)$), which basically says each nodal branching is 2, and the incremental depth contribution of each node is $\log_2(N)/N$ (so decreasing as N grows). A RRT with a base of e , and highly varied branching for any individual node, needs harmonic math rather than simple averages, but can be thought equivalently as an 'average branching of 2.71...' with an average height of $\ln(N)$. Number of leaves for an RRT is $n/2$, meaning half the nodes are 'children' or leaves.

Thirdly, this suggests that possibly, other noise types have structure to them (*white* is nodes in *series*, *brownian* is an *independent aggregation* of all influences *directly to the root node*) — at least in oscillator space. This seems counterintuitively flipped at first glance. But then you consider real time to Fourier relationships ($\delta \leftrightarrow \text{constant}$, $\text{rect} \leftrightarrow \text{sinc}$, $\text{convolution} \leftrightarrow \text{multiplication}$, $\text{decay} \leftrightarrow \text{lorentzian}$, etc) and consider we're seeing oscillators interact with each other, and revealing their packing relationships in that space.

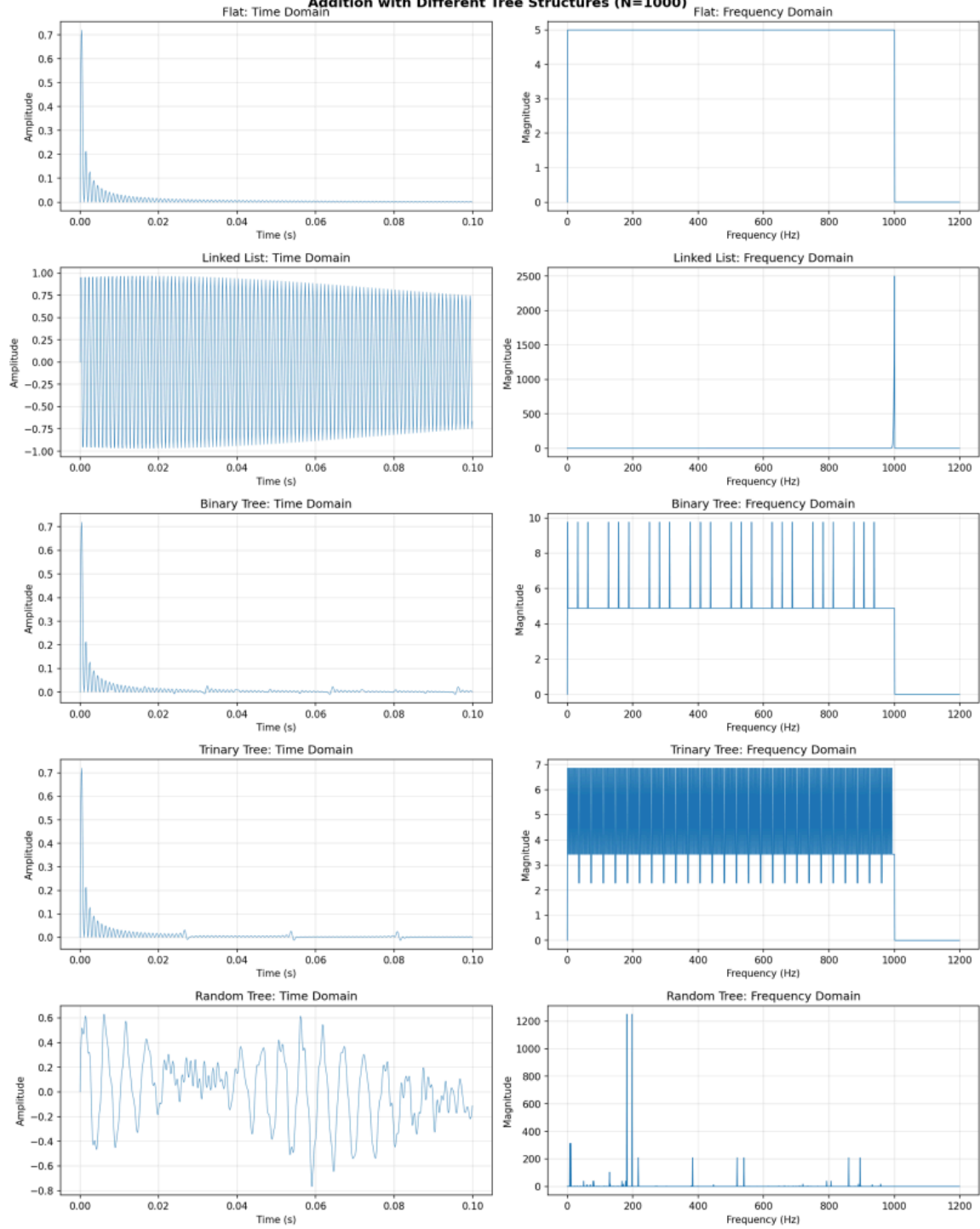
- Johnson-Nyquist Thermal Noise — is a particular known type of 'real' white noise system where the PSD of the voltage appears white when measured

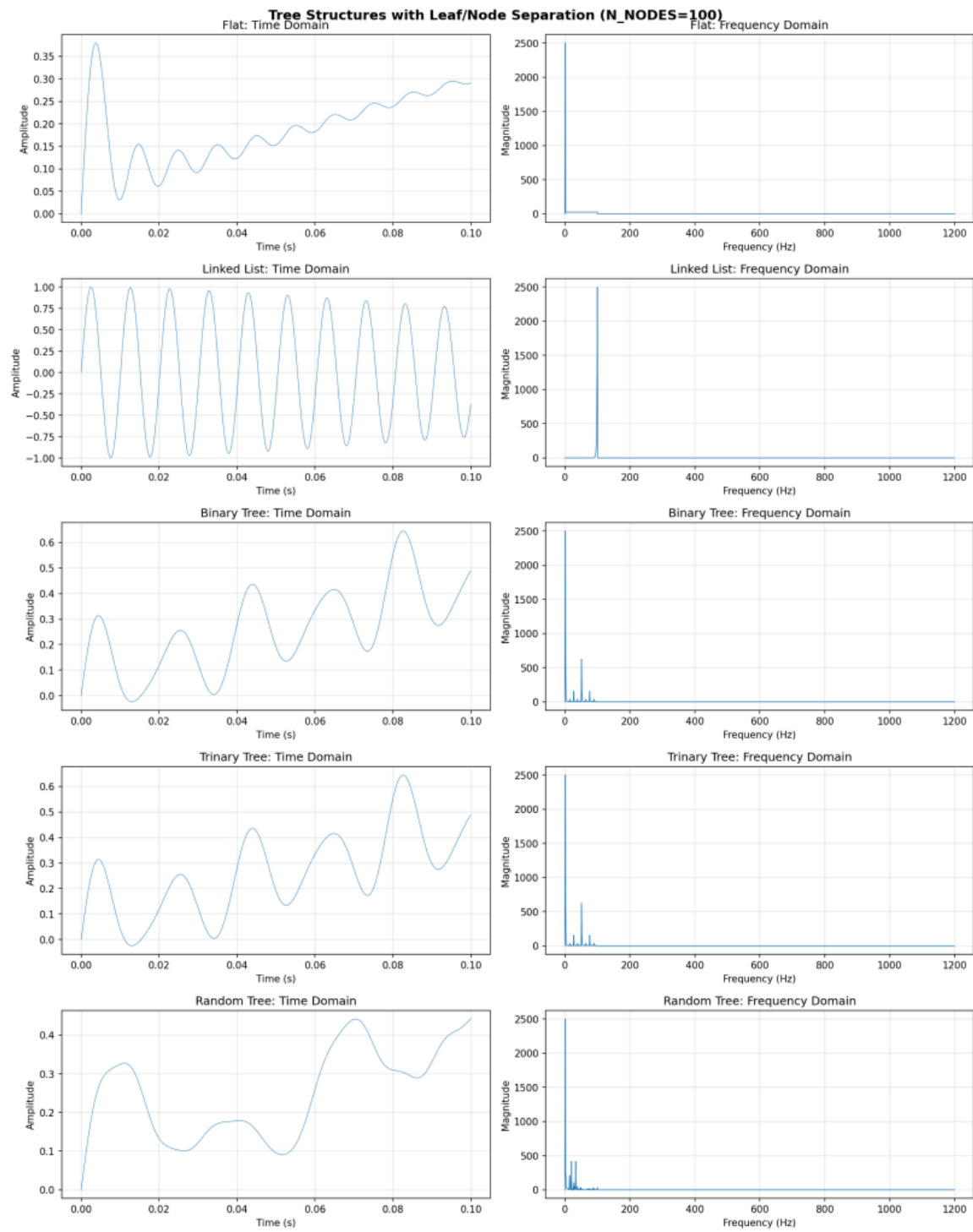
across a resistor at room temperature. So whether the: individual physical atoms of the resistor are contributing in parallel to the aggregate electron movement, that in the flipped space, the thermally-created oscillations appear serial, seems suggested but not entirely clear to me.

- Similarly, whether Brownian motion, which is an integrated (memory/state) history of perturbations on a system, in the flipped space, represents a perfectly parallel series of independent contributors (rather than the intuitive linked list structure) when in oscillator space.
- For instance, the autocorrelation function and PSD are Fourier transform pairs (at least for 'stationary random processes'), so white noise PSD, becomes a delta autocorrelation (only correlates with itself at no lag).
- I suspect the transforms of these structures from oscillatory space would give us the more intuitive structures in real space (Brown: linked list, which serially integrates inputs; White: flat tree, which combines in parallel many random sources independently — although *not* gaussian; to *produce* a flat spectra — not to be confused with the rect/sinc Fourier relationship), and therefore, the RRT structure may interestingly have a mirror relationship (much like gaussian ↔ gaussian), as a result of its balanced branching/depth structure.

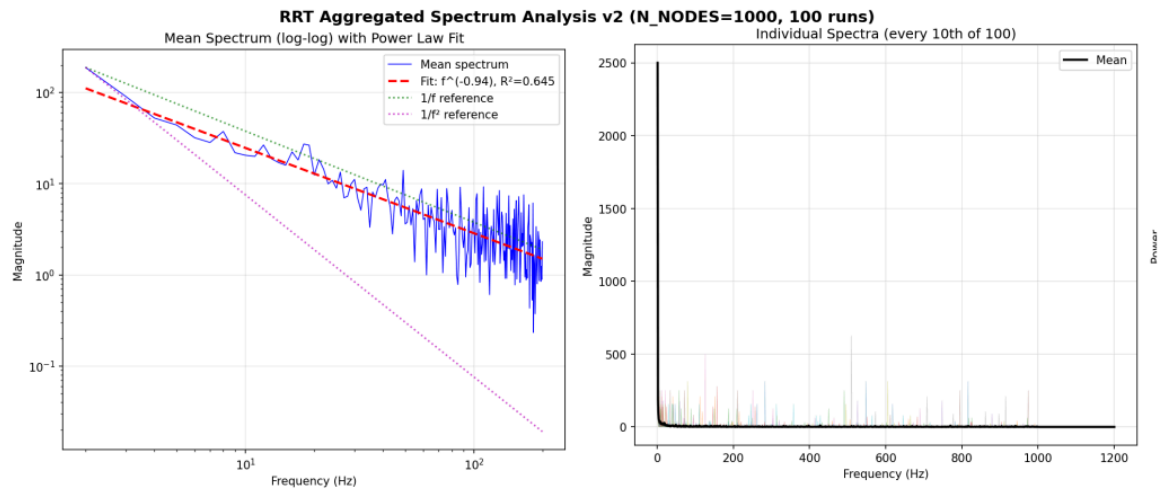
Finally, below, I include some simulations with different tree structures using the minimal operations required for tree structures to have meaning (e.g. normalized means of simple uniform spaced waveforms; commutative, but non-associative operators). Also, note how the RRT signals look more "biological."

Addition with Different Tree Structures (N=1000)

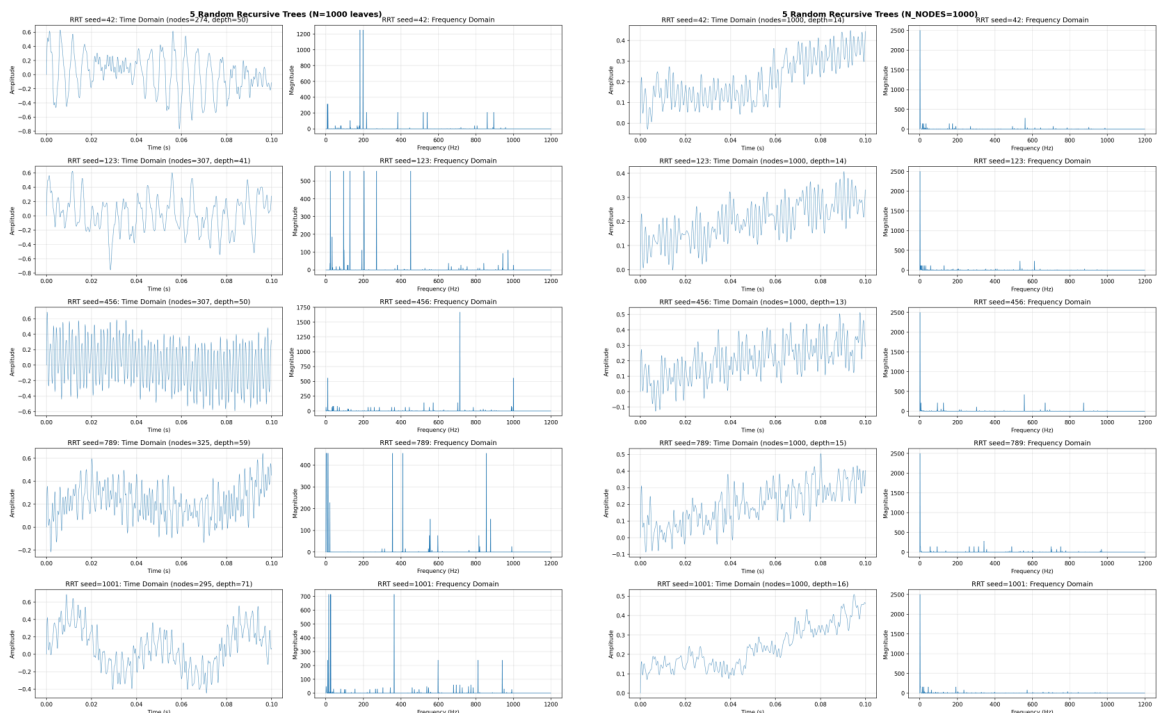




And the spectra of the RRT, over many runs.



Some more RRT generated signals to admire:



Theory #2: *Pink noise occurs whenever the correlation of frequency-dependent signals are equivalent to the correlation of frequency-independent signals.*

Lets start with a set of apparent observations that haven't been formally linked (anywhere I can find):

1. SNR (signal-to-noise) ratio has an interesting property of $1/\sqrt{N}$.
 - This actually arises from first-principles derivation of: signal power/noise power = $\text{var}(s)/\text{var}(n)$, which gets into basic statistical

math, yielding $= (1/N^2) [\sum_i E[s_i^2] + \sum_{i \neq j} E[s_i s_j]]$

2. $SNR^2 = (1/\sqrt{N})^2 = 1/N$, which looks like $PSD = 1/f$
 - This implies a **frequency-dependent sampling** of underlying signal sources that is responsible for varying signal powers across the spectrum.
3. Fourier sampling *intrinsically* has differential sampling (within a fixed time window)
 - $N=TF$ (low frequencies have less samples, higher frequencies more).
4. Now, assume we aren't dealing with 'signal' and 'noise' per se, but the ratio between two different 'sources' of signal (one being privileged in the observation over the other), we can get:
 - $P(f) = A(f)^2 \propto (1/f) \cdot [1 + (Tf-1)p_{fi}]/[1 + (Tf-1)p_{fd}]$
5. For the math of the different noise colors to work out, essentially, I'm assuming the denominator of our observed PSD, formerly the *noise* in the SNR equation, is now the '*signal who's variance is not frequency dependent*' and the numerator is 'frequency-dependent signal.'
 - Keep in mind that all pink spectra examples are in the context of using physical sensors to record and then Fourier math to create a PSD.
6. Regardless of physical interpretation of correlations and variances, this basic statistical math gives us a nice pattern:
 - $p_{fi} = 1, p_{fd} = 0 \rightarrow P(f) \propto \text{constant}$ (white)
 - $p_{fi} = 0, p_{fd} = 1 \rightarrow P(f) \propto 1/f^2$ (brown)
 - and pink, the special case, where *any* p_{fd} works as long as its equal to p_{fi} :
 - $p_{fi} = p_{fd} \rightarrow P(f) \propto 1/f$ (pink)

First, this implies that changing p_{fd} or p_{fi} (correlation of the freq-dep or freq-indep sources of signal) should impact the observed spectral slope, which is testable.

Secondly, this implies that a balance of two signal sources give rise to pink noise (which shouldn't be surprising as the integral of pink noise PSD is $\log[e](f)$). Specifically, the signal sources who's frequency variances are freq-dependent, equal the variance of frequency-independent signal sources, whether these are high or low or in between, gives us pink noise. Deviations from this balance towards a strong correlation of frequency-dependent signals leads to brown spectra, and frequency-independent leads to white spectra.

Thirdly, this allows for any organized distribution of frequency-dependent variation in amplitudes (the frequency dependence *potentially* coming from diminishing SNR with decreased numbers of high frequency channels, neurons, etc — although we do not require this pattern or direction). As the spectra of this category of signals is perturbed (by a network activation, ion gradient, etc), it can maintain a pink spectra as long as the opposite category of frequency-independent sources are perturbed in such a way the magnitude of their change in variance/correlation is similar to the frequency-dependent changes.

For brains, whether that's 'intrinsic' processes (time keeping, etc) keeping a balance with 'activity-driven' processes, as each category spreads itself in frequency space fairly equally, this theory gives a framework to categorize signal sources. Potentially, and more mundane of an explanation, this could mean that pink spectra in brains is a result of sensor noise or biological transmission noise, but likely is not given this observations of $1/f$ at the ion channel level, axon level, and dendrite level, as well as across modalities of measurement.

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Conclusion

I find these two theories/explanations superior to many other theories because these are: (a) derived from simple first-principles (random node addition, or simple statistical variance) with minimal assumptions, (b) don't import/fit complex terms to essentially curve-fit, (c) don't import a $1/f$ assumption to circularly derive a $1/f$ pattern, (d) also explaining the other spectra colors. They also have the advantage of not dealing with pulse trains and keeping the problem in oscillatory space for better intuition.

I also find these conceptual frameworks more intuitive. One requires imagining populations of oscillatory generators propagating through each other in simple graph structures. The other requires populations of oscillatory generators to simply have differences (or not) in internal variance, or, be differentially sensitive (or not) to perturbations.

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